

ETHIKA

UNDERWEAR

IS TOO

LONG

“It’s hard to pinpoint when everything started”, said the professor. He was tall and thin but not as if he skipped meals more like a byproduct of a lifetime running. His hair was fading in a timely way, and his voice was soft spoken. His eyes however contained an intensity that captivated all but the most uncaring of students.

“The prevailing theory is that the invention of the Gutenberg press and it’s latent sibling the typewriter kicked off the re-wiring of the human mind.” He always liked to start a lecture with bold claims, especially in an auditorium of this size. From up here in the second to last row I can see 100 students strewn about the three sections of the room. There are two walkways running up and down either side of the central corridor and two more on the far sides of the left and right sections. Every seat is slightly angled forward to give the heir of attention, and the building itself has been dug into the slope of a hill, so much so irrigation and landscaping must have been central topics in the construction process.

“What I am speaking about is a pernicious hollowing of our literature and speech. How many of you have read old letters or passages of books from antiquity and thought they were the most beautiful and eloquent writing you have ever read?” A few hands to my left and right shoot up.

“Take for example this excerpt from a letter written by Sullivan Ballou, a lawyer and officer in the union army, to his wife Sarah the night before he went to battle. He wrote, “If the dead can come back to this earth and flit unseen around those they loved, I shall always be near you; in the brightest day and in the darkest

night - amidst your happiest scenes and gloomiest hours - always, always; and if there be a soft breeze upon your cheek, it shall be my breath; or the cool air fans your throbbing temples, it shall be my spirit passing by."

At this point even myself and the other back row academics are enthralled.

"Now Mr. Ballou may have gone on to become the pre-eminent poet of his generation, but his leg was blown off by a six inch cannonball and he quickly succumbed to his injuries. There are many more Mr. Ballou's and what I mean to show in the next hour is how language is tied to the instruments and mediums that we use to read and write. Our ability to feel remains unchanged however our expression morphs to meet methods."

"Writing among common folk has dated back to around the year 900..." A hand near the front row apprehensively rises catching the professors attention.

"Yes, you have a question?"

"Sorry, I was just wondering how this topic pertains to our class on digital marketing?" It is a fair point, up until now our classes have taught us theories on slogan creation, copyright, color theory, or how to run focus groups to decide the next font for a customer portal.

The professor walked towards the center of the presentation pit and set aside his clicker which he was fond of using to rapidly wheel through slides in his presentations. He took a few breaths in thought and stood more straight up and down as if making himself into an antenna.

"Let me be more blunt. This lecture will discuss how humans have recently diverged from an evolution with analog tools, which were extensions of our own cognitive and motor skills, into a technological world where we no longer, on an interactive

level, understand how our tools work. Because of this missing connection there is an intense desire and affection for “vintage” and nostalgia. As marketing students if you understand this theory you will be able to tap into an abundance of material which will give you new ideas and mediums that capture the innate sense of quality that analog devices output.”

Someone in the front right fidgeted slightly re-adjusting their hat. Every back of head was transfixed and I could tell all eyes were too. This lecture already felt abnormal like an inner door was being cracked slightly revealing light from beyond.

“And more broadly as humans the topics and details within this lecture will hopefully give you an understanding that our brains are changing with our devices. By widening the scope of machinery and materials used for reading, writing, and visualization you can unlock connections that will increase thought and expression in a powerful way.”

And so he continued, upon completing the lecture there was no bell, no glancing eyes towards the clock on the far wall, just his dismissal. I saw every student walking out of that sunken auditorium without a hand reaching towards pant pockets to retrieve phones. The act would have felt blasphemous after the last hour.

When I got back to my dorm room, for the first time in college, I dug through a black milk crate stored beneath my desk until I found a stack of monogrammed card-stock my mom gave me along with stamps and envelopes to write home. They no longer felt weightless.

I wrote about my walk to class. Ruminating on how wide the sidewalks were. How they felt like freeways inlaid with bronze etched names. I described the tall trees that lined the fields in-between white stone buildings.

And how before a storm these trees shivered in the wind wrapping their arms about themselves. I explained that when the rain did fall how it worked in conjunction with the hilltop wind to dodge umbrellas and jackets pivoting in mid air to hone in on unprotected legs. I even mentioned a note about a girl I met in English. Meeting her has dulled my annoyance about having to retake that class. There's something special about our chance interaction.

While I write my thoughts flow out and sit in front of me dancing in inky blackness as they solidify. It's a soothing sensation. Maybe my professor is on to something.

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ALMOST TOUCHES MY KNEES
MAYBE MY LEGS ARE SHRINKING
I DOUBT IT